

Ethical AI and Data Privacy Policy

Newcastle Smart Peer Companion

1. Purpose

This policy explains how Newcastle Smart Peer Companion platform will use artificial intelligence and handle student data in an ethical, private and responsible manner. The platform is designed to support peer collaboration and not to replace student discussion or continuously monitor student conversations.

2. AI Activation Rule

The AI assistant will only be activated when users intentionally call or tag it in the chat. It will not automatically read, monitor or analyse all student conversations in the background.

For example, students may call the AI when they need help with:

- Understanding a difficult concept
- Summarising or explaining an uploaded PDF
- Clarifying a question during group discussion
- Getting support when the group is stuck

The AI should act as an optional learning assistant. It should not act as a hidden observer or surveillance tool.

3. Student Chat Privacy

Student chats should remain private within the relevant study group. The AI should not access or process chat messages unless students directly request AI assistance.

When the AI is tagged or activated only the relevant message, question or selected content should be sent for AI processing. No chat history or personal messaging must be uploaded to the AI.

This allows the students to exercise control over the use of the AI as well as ensures the privacy of the students during peer discussions.

4. Uploaded PDF and File Handling

Students may upload PDFs or learning materials to support group study but before uploading, users should be informed that uploaded files may be processed by the system for learning related features like text extraction, summarisation or AI assisted explanation.

The uploaded files should only be used for the purpose of supporting the student's study group. The platform should not use uploaded PDFs for unrelated purposes, external sharing or AI training without clear permission.

The system should apply basic file handling rules, including:

- Users should only upload files they are allowed to use.
- File uploads need to be accessible to authorised users only.
- File uploads should be checked for allowed file types and size limits.
- Uploaded materials should be stored securely.
- Users should be informed how their uploaded files will be used.

5. Consent

Users should provide their consent before using AI assisted features or uploading files. The consent notice should explain that:

- Uploaded materials may be processed by the system.
- AI generated responses may be based on uploaded content or user questions.
- AI responses may be inaccurate or incomplete.
- Users should review and discuss AI responses critically.

Remember that the AI is a tool which can be used to augment the educational process but does not provide the ultimate answers.

6. Using AI Responsibly

The AI assistant should support learning and collaboration not to replace student thinking. Students should not blindly rely on AI generated answers. Instead, the platform should facilitate discussions and reviews on the AI answers provided.

But it should be noted that the answers received from artificial intelligence can sometimes be wrong and biased, and students need to understand this point very well since they have the responsibility for checking the information.

7. Academic Integrity

The platform should be used to support understanding, discussion and revision. It should not be used to generate work for students to submit as their own without proper effort or acknowledgement.

The AI should be positioned as a learning support tool within peer collaboration not as a shortcut for completing assessments.

8. Data Access and Security

The platform should include basic privacy and cybersecurity controls to protect students data and uploaded materials. These may include:

- User authentication
- Role based access control
- Secure storage of uploaded files
- Password protection and hashing
- File upload validation
- Restricted access to study group materials
- Limiting AI access to only requested content

Only authorised users should be able to access group chats, uploaded files and related study materials.

9. Data Minimisation

The platform should only collect and process data that is necessary for the project's learning and collaboration features. It should avoid collecting unnecessary personal information.

Where possible, the system should process only the specific content required for the AI request, rather than full chat histories or unrelated files.

10. Transparency

Users should be clearly informed when the AI is being used. AI generated responses should be identifiable so students know the difference between peer messages and AI generated content.

The platform should also explain that AI is activated only when requested and does not continuously monitor all chat activity.

11. Summary of Platform Rules

Area	Rule
AI activation	AI only activates when tagged or requested by users
Chat privacy	AI does not continuously monitor all conversations
Uploaded PDFs	Files are processed only for study-related support features
Consent	Users must be informed before uploading files or using AI features
AI responses	AI outputs must be reviewed and discussed critically
Access control	Only authorised users should access group chats and uploaded materials
Data use	Student data should not be used for unrelated purposes
Academic integrity	AI should support learning, not replace student effort

12. Policy Statement

The Newcastle Smart Peer Companion will use AI in a controlled, transparent and student centred way. The access to the AI system shall depend on the demand from the students, and the system will not continually track their activities. The AI system must ensure student privacy, promote AI ethics, and promote collaboration among peers instead of competition.